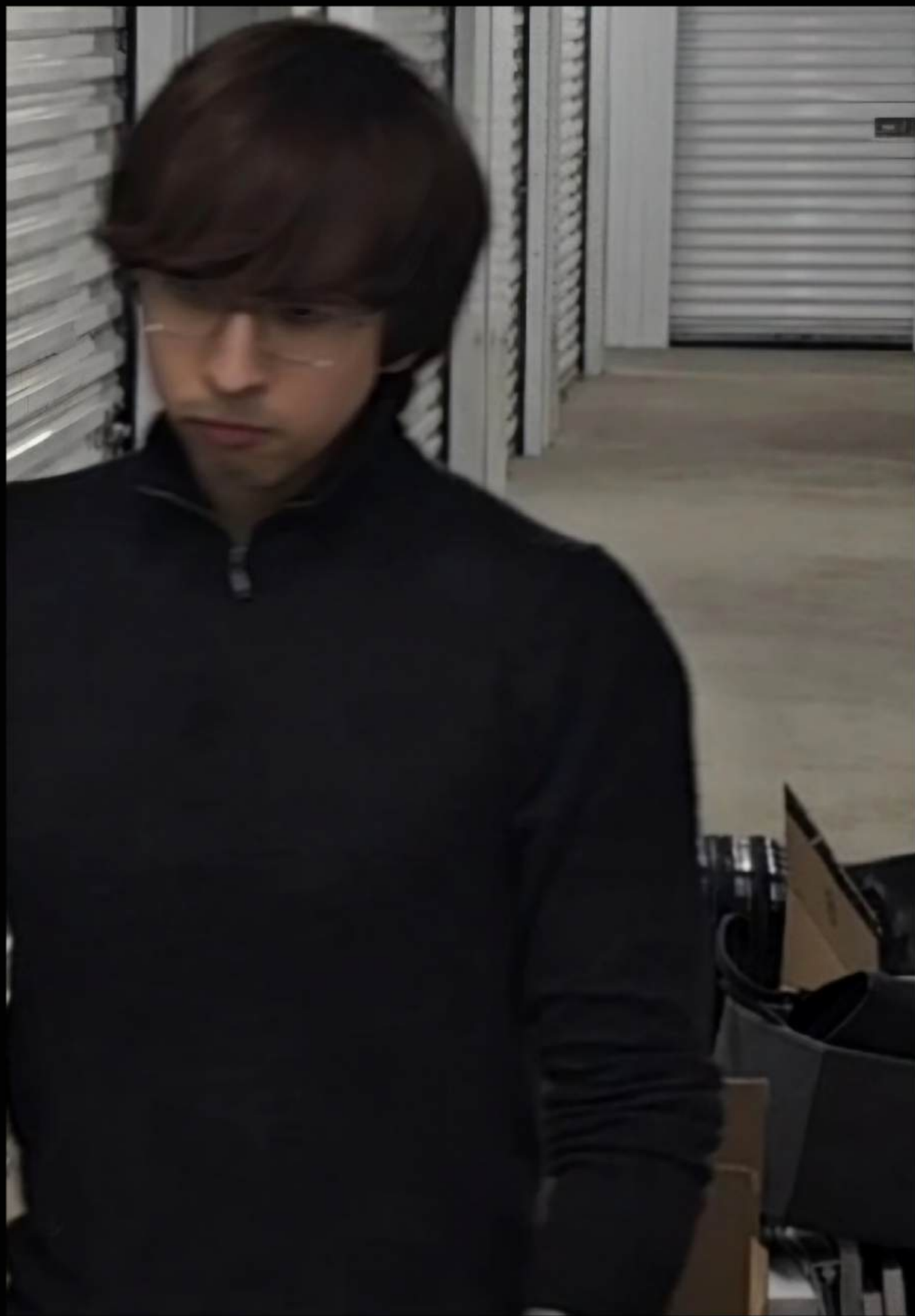




REFLECTIONS

Vincent A.V-S.

Onward

Choosing to live in a car is a big decision, but not bigger than choosing to tell your parents about it.



I obsessed over how I might tell them, and how I would explain it to the uninitiated.

But eventually, I couldn't lie to them anymore. So, I just poured it on them. Of course, I didn't actually tell them. Instead, I just sent them videos of people living in their cars, with messages along the lines of, "Brace yourself."

It was such a relief—especially given that it finally pushed my mother over the edge as she began offering me money.

Technically, she owes me \$40,000 in weekly allowance—unpaid since I turned 18.

But as I began ideating my own explanation for all of this, I kept repeating this line: "Living in my car."

What does that even mean?

Then a question struck me:

What really is *living*?

When I "lived" in an apartment, I often joked when customer service representatives asked me if I still lived at 201 Broad Street: "Well, I wouldn't call it *living*, but yes, I do *reside* there."



And now that I'm roaming the United States while living in a 2016 Ford Mustang, I can't help but wonder if I'm living yet—and, if I've ever lived at all.

But when I thought about defining what *living* is, I was at a loss for words.

At that point, I was reminded of an excerpt from the book *How to Think Like a Cat* by Stéphane Garnier. It was, and is, at least for now, a good definition of *living*:

"Freedom, cherished freedom. Who hasn't dreamed of making freedom the driving force of their life?

Freedom to come and go, freedom to do only that which pleases you, freedom of action, freedom to follow your whims and heart's desires, freedom to be as free in your mind as you are in your body. Freedom!"

That's what living is, isn't it? Freedom.

And that's what I was after when I chose to live in a 2016 Ford Mustang. It was freedom I was chasing on I-95 North—through Connecticut, Rhode Island, and Massachusetts—cherished freedom.

Freedom to come and go—to do only that which pleases me—to realize my desires—to be as free in my mind as I was in that car.

Cherished freedom.



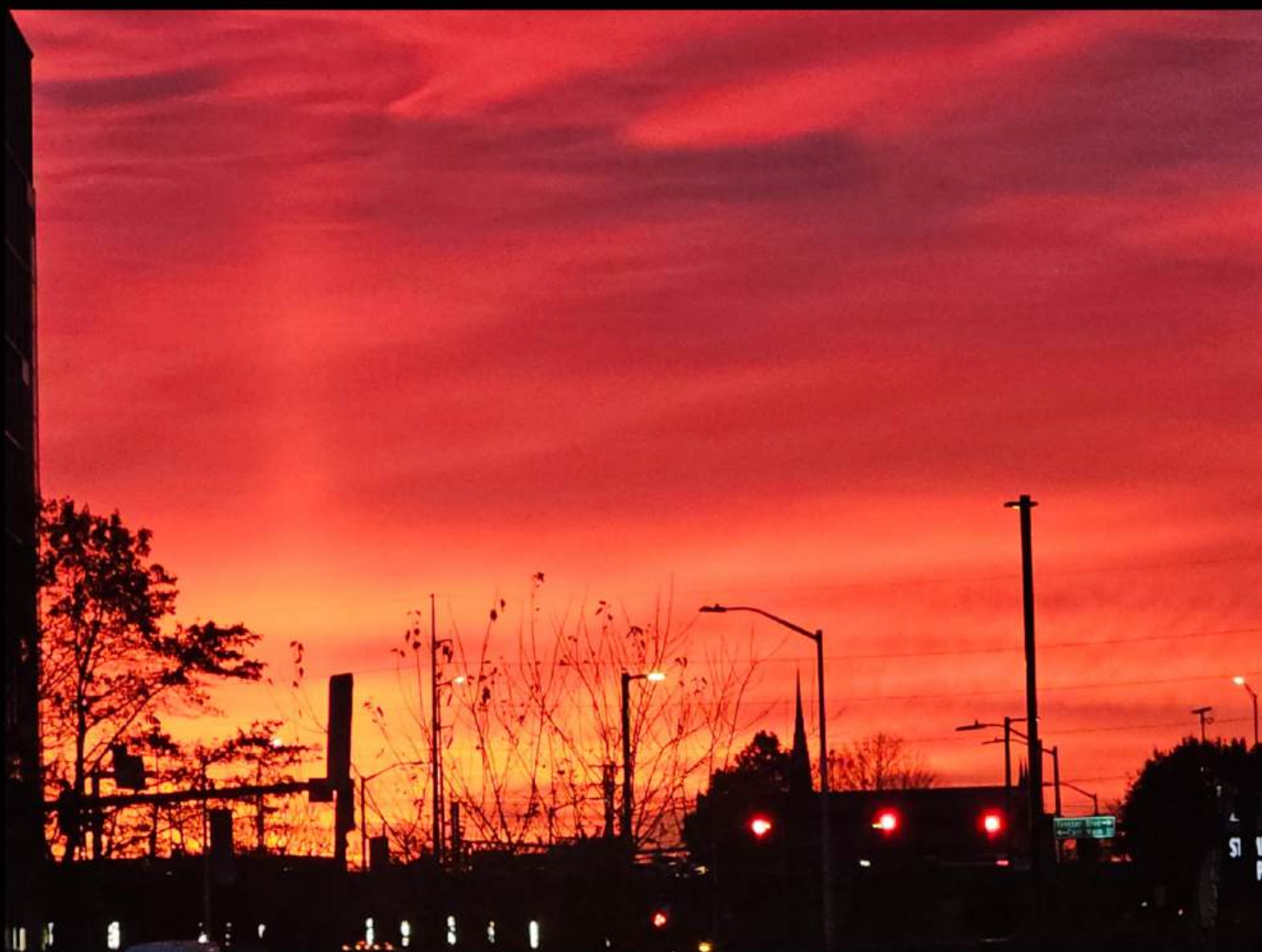
Storage Unit

*Removing the seats
from my car.*





LEAVING STAMFORD, CT



First week in R.I. This spot made me want to camp.



In North Eastern CT...





Waiting out Winter Storms—Fern and Gwen—at
the Mohegan Sun Winter Garage in
Uncasville, CT. Over 50-inches of snow fell.





Providence, RI...



Practicing Photography

I finally made time to practice photography in manual mode.



Billy C. caught me off guard when he walked into my frame and said, "Cheese!" I offered to take a photo of them, and it's one of my favorites so far—despite being slightly blurry. I should've taken it in auto mode.

I took the pictures below in Providence and Massachusetts.

I saw the Turkey walking around a bank in the city. I was like, "What!" I pulled over to photograph him—or her. I almost had to stop a moving car with my bare hands and super strong legs.











My First Candid

CATCHING CANDIDS

What sets photojournalistic pictures apart from other types of photography? The photojournalistic style depends on catching candid moments. Good photojournalists have developed the instinct to be at the right place, at the right time, with the right lens and camera. Often, they can steal images like a

Examples from the Pros below:



Using a 300mm f/2.8 telephoto lens, the photographer was able to remain in the distance. With a long lens, a photographer can often shoot pictures without being observed.

(© Photo by George Martell, the *Boston Herald*.)



Although both women were aware of the photographer, he was still able to capture this candid interaction between a 72-year-old high school student and her classmate. The women were more fascinated by one another than they were by the photographer's presence.

(Photo by Ronald Cortes, *The Philadelphia Inquirer*.)



My first candids below. Don't worry—it's totally legal to photograph people in public without their knowing (so long as I'm not harassing them). They're also a bit blurry. I should've switched to auto mode...I need a longer lens for zoom shots.



Saving Lives and Ambulance Chasing

This bird (a House Finch) had a common, healable eye disease. It was flightless because it was basically blind. So, I called a rehabilitator in the area and managed to put it in a box for them.



At one point, I wanted to be a doctor. Not for ethical reasons, of course; I just wanted a job that paid lots of money. Now, I live in my car and

save lives. Go figure.



On another note, my sixth grade reading teacher told me that I would never be a lawyer. After successfully completing the Summer Law School Preparation Academy at UTSA, I decided I didn't want to be a lawyer. But at least I can say I'm an experienced ambulance chaser.



In your face, Ms. Krueger.

The Junk that Ruled my Life



As I walked through the rubble of what I once called home, I couldn't help but think that it represented my life's work. And, I couldn't help but think that it was all junk—

approximately \$10,000 worth. I was preparing to abandon all of it after I had deliberated on the idea for several months.

Once I picked out my invaluable items—mostly photos, some



paperwork, Papa's briefcase and the mementos inside of it—I felt the shackles unlock as I drove off into the night.

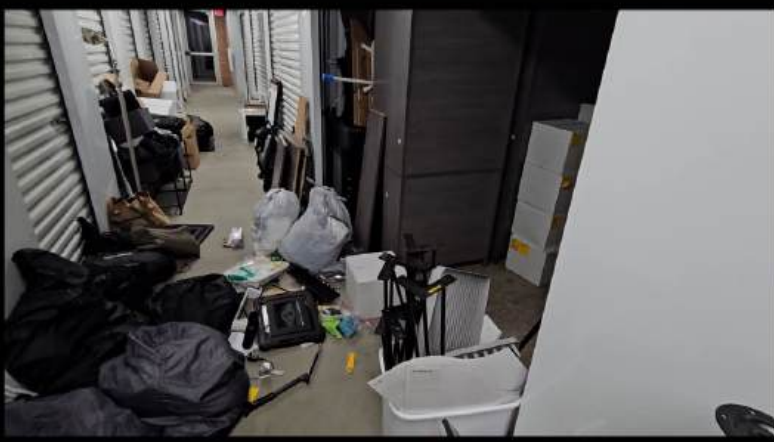
It reminded me of the first time I slept in my car, in a new

city. It wasn't a planned decision. I simply decided to do so because I could. Everything I needed was in that car. It was



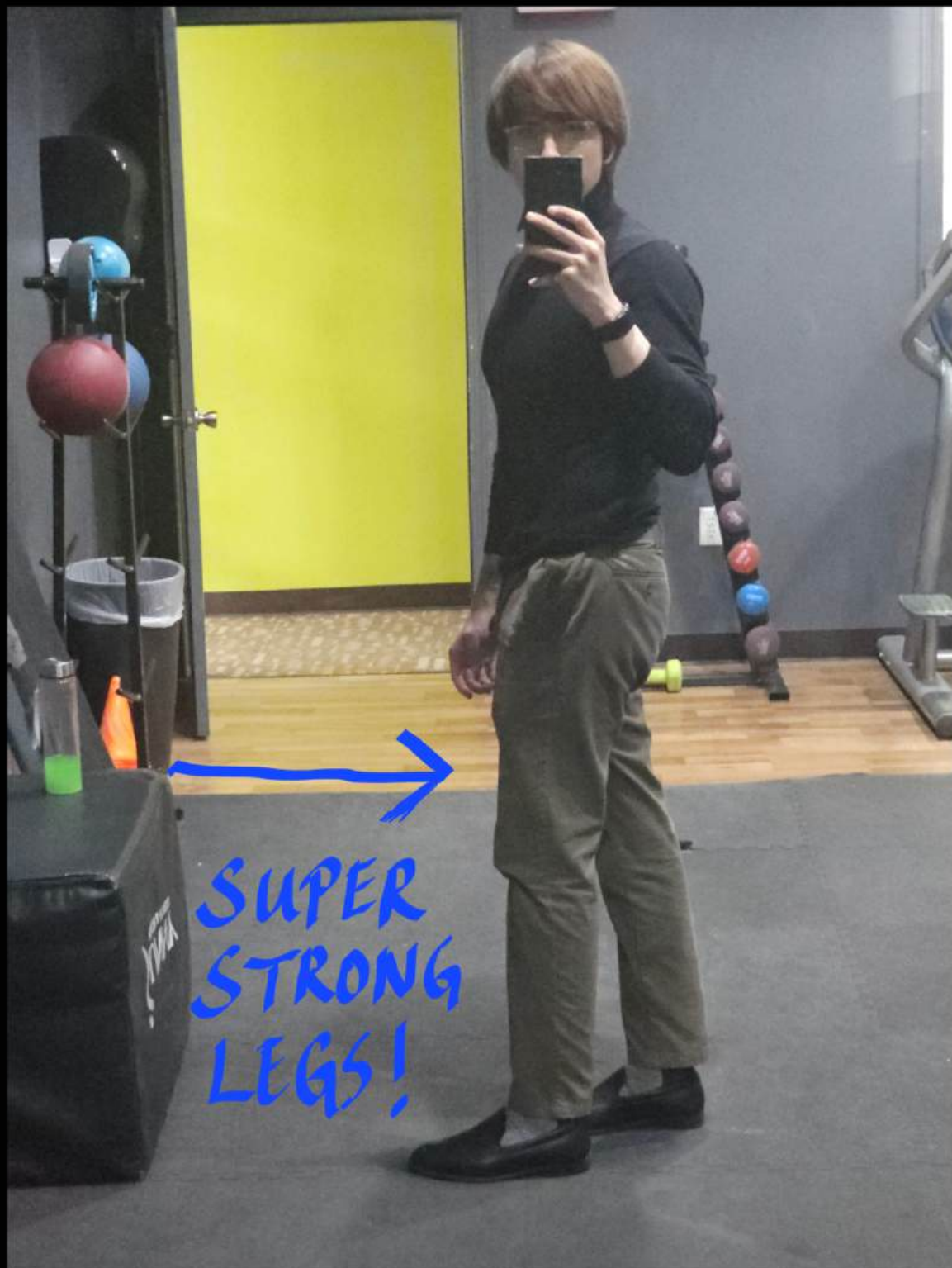
honestly a euphoric feeling. But I felt I couldn't go much farther from my storage unit—as if I might need something from there. Even 200 miles away, the things I owned still owned me.

Not anymore.



The next time I decide to spend \$10,000 on furniture, appliances, and the like, I'll make sure I own the land it resides on.





With Love,
Vincent A.V-S.
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